

Mehrangarh Fort

A formidable 15th-century fort that towers in splendor above the city of Jodhpur



One of India's largest, most spectacular, and best-preserved forts, Mehrangarh ("citadel of the Sun" in Sanskrit), in Jodhpur, Rajasthan, was built by Jodhpur's founder, Rao Jodha (1416–1489). Following his decision to move the capital from nearby Mandore to a more secure location, the fort was founded in 1459, although it was modified and expanded considerably by successive generations. Situated on top of a red-sandstone cliff 400 ft (122 m) above the now-sprawling city, the majestic structure continues to dominate the skyline.

Giant defenses

Enclosed by formidable walls 120 ft (37 m) high and 69 ft (21 m) wide, the fortress covers an area of around 860,000 square ft (80,000 square m). It boasts seven gateways and contains several

opulent palaces, apartments, and reception rooms constructed or embellished by rulers at different periods. These are notable for, among other things, their intricate stonework, carved balconies, elegant courtyards and arches, and beautiful latticed *jali* screens in pink or yellow sandstone. The *mahal*, or palaces, often comprise a single, highly ornamented room, as in the Moti Mahal ("pearl palace") or the Phool Mahal ("flower palace"). Watchtowers, massive ramparts, and a series of strategically placed cannons along the battlements are also distinctive features of the site.

At the southern end of Mehrangarh Fort is the 15th-century temple dedicated to the Hindu goddess Chamunda Devi, revered by Rao Jodha. It houses an idol of the goddess, which he transported from his former capital at Mandore in 1460.



△ MOTI MAHAL

This 16th-century throne room of the Moti Mahal is notable for its vibrant stained-glass windows, alcoves, octagonal throne, and opulent gilt ceiling adorned with mirrors and crushed shells.

▽ CITADEL OF THE SUN

Built high on a red-sandstone cliff, the formidable Mehrangarh Fort dominates the landscape, towering above the modern city of Jodhpur and its distinctive blue houses.

One gateway of the fort bears the imprint of cannonballs fired in battle

